

Permission: Can, Could & May

CEFR A2

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

Can, could and may all handle permission, at different levels of formality:

- 1 Ask — Can/Could/May I...? (can = informal, may = formal).
- 2 Give — You can / You may (not 'could').
- 3 Refuse — You can't / You may not.

'Could' asks politely but isn't used to give permission: 'Could I...?' → 'Yes, you can.' (not 'you could').

At a glance

Function	Words	Example
Ask (informal)	Can I...?	Can I sit here?
Ask (polite)	Could I...?	Could I borrow your pen?
Ask (formal)	May I...?	May I come in?
Give	You can / You may	You can go now. You may begin.
Refuse	You can't / You may not	You can't park here.

Learning objectives

- Can ask permission with can/could/may at the right level of formality (CEFR A2).
- Can give and refuse permission with can/may and can't/may not.
- Can avoid giving permission with 'could'.

Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Permission: Can, Could & May · CEFR A2

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. ____ I sit here? (informal)

- | | |
|---------|-----------|
| A. Can | B. May |
| C. Must | D. Should |

2. ____ I come in? (formal, at an office)

- | | |
|---------|----------|
| A. May | B. Can |
| C. Must | D. Would |

3. 'Could I borrow your charger?' — 'Yes, you ____.'

- | | |
|------------|----------|
| A. can | B. could |
| C. may not | D. must |

4. Sorry, you ____ park here — it's for staff only.

- | | |
|----------|-------------|
| A. can't | B. couldn't |
| C. may | D. should |

5. ____ I ask you a question, please? (polite)

- | | |
|-----------|---------|
| A. Could | B. Must |
| C. Should | D. Will |

6. Students ____ use the lab after 6 p.m. (giving permission, formal)

- | | |
|---------|-----------|
| A. may | B. could |
| C. must | D. should |

7. Passengers ____ smoke anywhere on the train.

- | | |
|------------|-----------|
| A. may not | B. may |
| C. could | D. can be |

8. Correct this: 'Can I to leave early today?'

- | | |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| A. Can I leave early today? | B. Can I to leave early today? |
| C. Can to I leave early today? | D. May I to leave early today? |

9. 'May I take your coat?' is an example of...

- | | |
|---|-----------------------|
| A. a formal, polite request for permission. | B. giving permission. |
| C. refusing permission. | D. asking for advice. |

10. Which is used to ASK but not to GIVE permission?

- | | |
|----------|-----------|
| A. could | B. can |
| C. may | D. cannot |

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **A. Can** — 'Can I...?' is the everyday way to ask permission.
2. **A. May** — 'May I...?' is the formal way to ask permission.
3. **A. can** — Give permission with 'can', not 'could'.
4. **A. can't** — Refuse permission with 'can't': 'you can't park here'.
5. **A. Could** — 'Could I...?' is a polite way to ask permission.
6. **A. may** — Formal permission uses 'may': 'Students may use the lab'.
7. **A. may not** — Formal refusal: 'may not smoke'.
8. **A. Can I leave early today?** — Modals take the base verb with no 'to': 'Can I leave...?'
9. **A. a formal, polite request for permission.** — 'May I...?' is a formal, polite way to ask.
10. **A. could** — 'Could' asks politely but isn't used to give permission.